

RESEARCH EVIDENCE MEMO

Can India Be Called the World's Second-Largest English-Speaking Country?

Claim audit, reproducible census calculation, and cross-country definition review

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Evidence cut-off: 18 August 2026

Status: Research memo; sources, calculations, conclusions, and disclosure reviewed and approved by Tripti

Executive verdict

The statement is **plausible as a qualified historical shorthand, but not verified as a current global ranking**.

India's official Census 2011 table C-17 records **128,539,090** people who named English as their mother tongue, first subsidiary language, or second subsidiary language [S01]. This figure is reproducible from the all-India workbook and is lower than the 129.3 million figure that appears in some secondary sources.

The United States is clearly larger: its 2024 American Community Survey reports **247,695,110** people age five or older who speak only English at home and **292,827,195** who speak only English or speak English "very well" [S05]. However, no harmonized international dataset applies India's "up to three languages known" measure to every country. Official sources for other countries ask different questions and cover different age or household universes.

The defensible conclusion is therefore not "proved second." It is:

India's 2011 Census recorded about 128.5 million people who named English as one of up to three languages known. That count is widely used to describe India as the second-largest English-speaking population after the United States, but the ranking is not a current, internationally harmonized statistic.

What the Indian census actually establishes

The Census of India C-17 table classifies every reported mother tongue by the first and second subsidiary languages spoken. It covers all individuals and publishes an all-India total [S01]. Recalculation of the official workbook gives:

Census 2011 category	Persons
English as mother tongue	259,678
English as first subsidiary language	82,717,239
English as second subsidiary language	45,562,173
English in any of the three positions	128,539,090

This count represents **10.62%** of the 2011 population of 1,210,854,977. It is a count of respondents naming English among up to three languages, not a tested fluency count. The C-17 catalog describes subsidiary languages but does not impose a common proficiency threshold [S01]. Census processing material identifies the underlying household questions as "Mother Tongue and Other Languages Known" [S03].

The Indian number is also old. The Census Division states that the last decennial population census was conducted in 2011; Census 2027 is underway but has not produced a new language table [S04]. Treating the 2011 count as a 2026 measurement would be a category error.

Why the United States is safely first

The U.S. comparison does not require a generous definition. The 2024 ACS subject table reports:

- population age five and over: 321,745,943;
- speak only English at home: 247,695,110; and
- speak English only or speak English "very well": 292,827,195 [S05].

Both English measures exceed India's 128.5 million. The questionnaires are not equivalent - the ACS begins with language spoken at home and excludes children under five - but the difference is large enough that it does not threaten the first-place conclusion.

Why second place is not proved

"English speaker" is not a standardized global census variable. The most relevant official sources illustrate the mismatch:

Geography and source	Published English measure	Count	Why it is not equivalent to India C-17
India, Census 2011	English among mother tongue plus two subsidiary languages	128,539,090	All ages; no shared proficiency threshold
United States, ACS 2024	English only at home	247,695,110	Age 5+; home-use question

Geography and source	Published English measure	Count	Why it is not equivalent to India C-17
United States, ACS 2024	English only or English "very well"	292,827,195	Age 5+; self-rated ability after home-language question
England and Wales, Census 2021	English/Welsh main language plus proficient English	about 56.7 million	Age 3+; main language and self-rated proficiency; not whole UK
Canada, Census 2021	Knowledge of English	31,628,570	Private households; ability to conduct a conversation; 25% sample
Australia, Census 2021	English only used at home	18,303,662	Home use, not all English ability; nonresponse present

England and Wales reported 52.6 million people age three or older with English (or English/Welsh in Wales) as a main language and another 4.1 million proficient in English [S06]. Canada reported 31,628,570 people with knowledge of English [S08]. Australia reported 18,303,662 people using only English at home; its statistical office explicitly warns that this is not a count of everyone who uses English [S10, S11]. These official counts do not challenge India's position, but they also cannot validate a global rank because their definitions differ.

Potential comparator countries create a larger evidence gap. Pakistan's 2023 census publishes population by mother tongue but does not publish a directly comparable national count of English ability in that table [S13, S14]. Nigeria's official household survey variables include school language and literacy questions, not a population-wide English-speaker count equivalent to C-17 [S15]. The Philippines' 2020 census publishes languages spoken at home and general literacy, not a directly comparable English-proficiency headcount [S16, S17].

The EF English Proficiency Index cannot close the gap. It ranks adult test performance rather than counting speakers, and EF states that its online test-taking population is self-selected and not guaranteed to represent the country [S12]. India's 2025 EF EPI rank of 74 is therefore relevant to proficiency among test takers, not to the size of India's English-speaking population [S18].

Strongest case for the claim

The strongest supporting argument is practical rather than strictly statistical:

1. India has a nationally enumerated count of 128.5 million people reporting English among three known languages.
2. The United States is demonstrably larger.
3. The official counts located for England and Wales, Canada, and Australia are much smaller.
4. Several other large countries lack a comparable official headcount, while widely circulated estimates still place India second.

Under the ordinary broad meaning "people who can use some English," describing India as second is reasonable shorthand. Academic work continues to repeat the roughly 130 million figure [S19], and Indian policy and commercial documents repeat the rank [S20]. The repetition shows that the phrase is established; it does not independently verify the methodology.

Strongest case against the claim

The strongest objection is that the ranking compares unlike measures and then presents the result as current:

- India counts a language named among up to three "known" languages, without a tested ability threshold.
- The United States and Australia start from home language.
- Canada asks conversational knowledge.
- England and Wales combine main language with self-rated proficiency.
- Some large countries do not publish a national English-ability count at all.
- India's observation is from 2011, fifteen years before the evidence cut-off.

These are not minor technical differences. They can change who qualifies by tens of millions. A person may know English but not use it at home; another may name English as known but have limited conversational ability. Until countries are measured under the same question and threshold, exact ordinal ranking is not established.

Decision and wording guidance

Unqualified claim

India is the world's second-largest English-speaking country.

Verdict: do not use as a standalone fact. It suppresses the date, definition, and comparability problem.

Qualified claim

India's 2011 Census recorded about 128.5 million people who named English as one of up to three languages known. That historical count is widely cited as the world's second largest after the United States, although no current harmonized global census confirms the ranking.

Verdict: defensible. It preserves the useful scale claim and exposes its limits.

Short public version

India had about 128.5 million self-reported English users in Census 2011 - commonly described as the second-largest national total after the United States, though cross-country definitions differ.

Verdict: acceptable if space is constrained and a source link is supplied.

What would change this conclusion

The verdict should be upgraded to "verified" only if a credible international source publishes contemporaneous country totals using one operational definition and representative samples or

censuses. The verdict should be downgraded if a comparable official national count above 128.5 million is found for another country or if the Indian C-17 interpretation is revised by the Census authority.

Research integrity note

The conclusion intentionally separates three propositions that are often blurred:

1. India had a very large Census 2011 count of people naming English - **verified**.
2. Only the United States had a larger count under available widely cited national figures - **plausible but not exhaustively verified**.
3. India is currently second under a consistent global definition - **not established**.

See sources.csv, claim-evidence-table.csv, and methodology.md for the complete evidence trail.

Selected source register

Primary sources and the most important methodological context are listed below. The complete 21-source register is supplied in sources.csv. Evidence grades: A = authoritative national source; B = credible secondary or methodological context.

S01 [A]. Office of the Registrar General & Census Commissioner, India. C-17: Population by bilingualism and trilingualism, India (2011). [Open source](#)

S03 [A]. Office of the Registrar General & Census Commissioner, India. Circular No. 39: Mother Tongue and Other Languages Known (2014). [Open source](#)

S04 [A]. Office of the Registrar General & Census Commissioner, India. Census Division (2026). [Open source](#)

S05 [A]. U.S. Census Bureau. S1601: Language Spoken at Home, 2024 ACS 1-Year Estimates (2024). [Open source](#)

S06 [A]. Office for National Statistics. Language, England and Wales: Census 2021 (2021). [Open source](#)

S08 [A]. Statistics Canada. Knowledge of languages by age and gender (2021). [Open source](#)

S09 [A]. Australian Bureau of Statistics. Language used at home (LANP) (2021). [Open source](#)

S10 [A]. Australian Bureau of Statistics. 2021 Census All persons QuickStats (2021). [Open source](#)

S12 [B]. EF Education First. About EF English Proficiency Index (2025). [Open source](#)

S13 [A]. Pakistan Bureau of Statistics. Table 11: Population by mother tongue (2023). [Open source](#)

S14 [A]. Pakistan Bureau of Statistics. 7th Population & Housing Census 2023: National Census Report (2023). [Open source](#)

S15 [A]. Nigeria National Bureau of Statistics. General Household Survey Panel 2023-2024 data dictionary (2024). [Open source](#)

S19 [B]. arXiv. Svarah: Evaluating English ASR Systems on Indian Accents (2023). [Open source](#)

S20 [B]. Government of India. Annexure III (2024). [Open source](#)